That was Pakistan's first military coup. Elections scheduled to have been held a few months after it started were canceled because of "lack of decorum, and the prostitution of Islam for political ends," as Ayub later put it.[1] The coup was bloodless. New American tanks appeared ominously at major intersections of every large Pakistani city that October morning in 1958, and traffic and trains were kept moving.

Twenty days after the coup, President Mirza was forced to resign and left Pakistan with his family, flying off to London exile. Ayub Khan awarded himself the title of president, establishing a pattern followed by all three of Pakistan's subsequent coup leaders. Explaining that it was the army's responsibility to protect Pakistan's people, since its politicians were letting the country "go to the dogs," Ayub said that he took up his new burden in a spirit of "selfless sacrifice." He dismissed as false charges that he coveted political power and insisted that he planned to return to barracks just as soon as order was restored. But that would take a decade longer.

Ayub hoped to reach some agreement with Nehru on Kashmir, and proposed to fly to India himself, but Nehru rejected the offer, viewing Ayub as a mere "lackey" of Washington, as well as the usurper of Pakistani civil power. After that, Ayub left the issue of Kashmir in the hands of his young foreign minister, Zulflkar Ali Bhutto, who engaged India's foreign minister, Swaran Singh, in six months of futile talks, seeking in vain to resolve their dispute over Kashmir.[2] Zulfi also convinced Ayub of the importance of courting China, whose charismatic foreign minister, Chou En-lai, most effectively challenged Nehru's claims to India's leadership of the uncommitted Third World of Asia and Africa. Sino-Pakistani friendship has been a keystone of Pakistan's foreign policy from 1962 to the present thanks to Bhutto. Two months before his first meeting with Swaran Singh in December 1962, China had invaded India over its northern border, wiping out Indian troops there and advancing virtually unopposed toward Assam's capital, Gauhati. This defeat of Indian forces cost Nehru's cabinet colleague V. K. Krishna Menon his job as minister of defense. Bhutto consolidated his diplomatic friendship with China by reaching agreement with Chou on Pakistan's northern border, ceding some 2,000 square miles of Kashmir State to China. Outraged, India vehemently protested to the UN Security Council that this unilateral action was unlawful, and Nehru almost aborted the Indo-Pakistani talks before they were launched. Nothing more came of